From Ashes to Assets

Digitising Cremation Burials with THANADOS

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THANADOS is an online platform based on the OpenAtlas database that provides access to interconnected archaeological burial data, enabling the comparative analysis of burial practices, grave goods, and archaeological contexts across sites and regions.

THANADOS: An Open Digital Infrastructure

- The Anthropological and Archaeological Database of Sepultures
- An open-access, web-based platform for archaeological burial data
- Built on the open-source framework OpenAtlas and developed at the Natural History Museum Vienna



Why Digitise Cremation Burials?

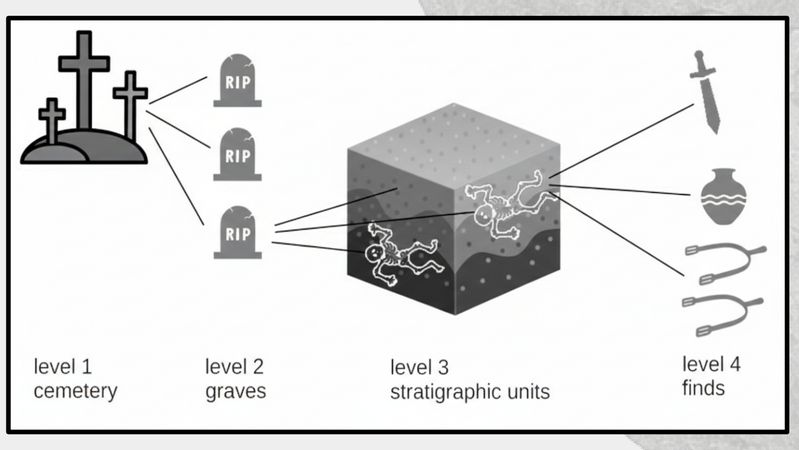
- Cremation burials and their associated finds present challenges for archaeological and anthropological analysis
- Diverse types of evidence need to be documented and linked within a coherent data structure
- Digital documentation facilitates the structured recording and exploration of cremation burials





A Semantic Approach to Burial Data

- Built on OpenAtlas, an open-source framework for managing archaeological and historical research data as well as related scientific information (anthropological analyses, radiocarbon dating, etc.)
- Based on CIDOC CRM, a standardised ontology for representing and linking information across the humanities

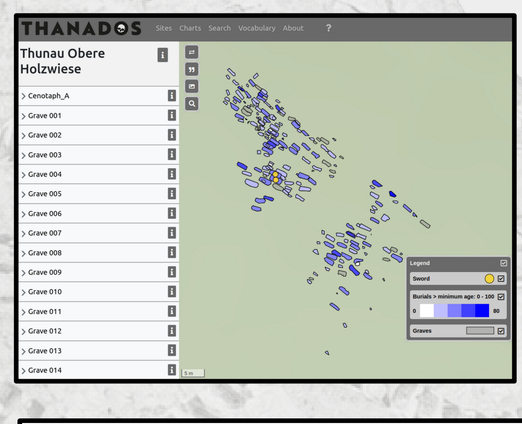


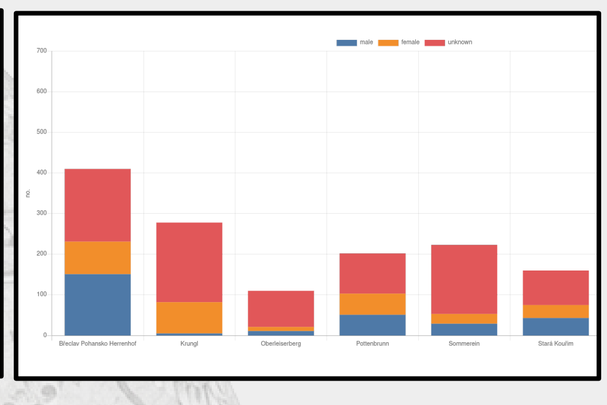
- Structured documentation – Relationships between entities are recorded in OpenAtlas and visualised on THANADOS
- Interoperability – Standardised data structures support the exchange and reuse of information

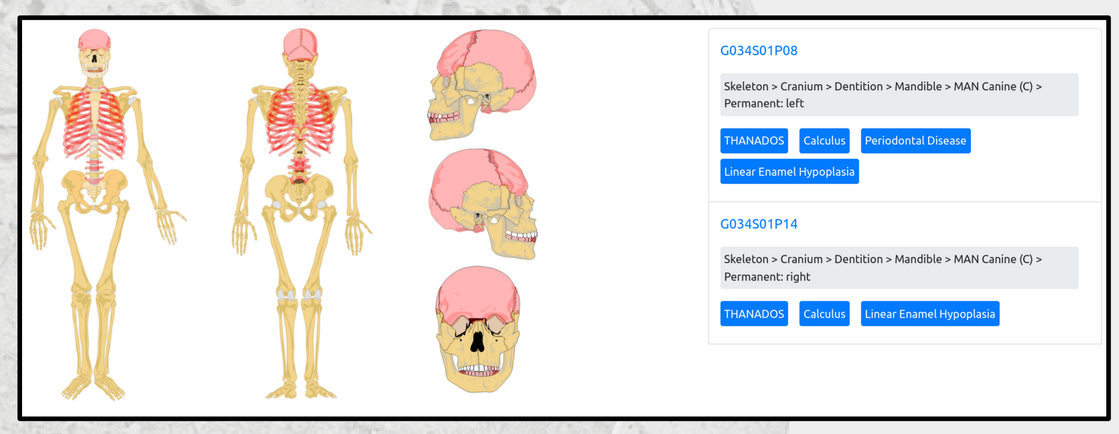
From Archaeological Context to Digital Data

- Documenting burial contexts and their archaeological setting
- Associated finds and their relationship to individual burials
- Anthropologic information is integrated where available
- Links to excavation records, metadata and authority files (e.g. Getty AAT)
- Information is published online – accessible for researchers and the wider public

Explore and Visualise Burial Data







Interactive map – Intra-site and inter-site query – Catalogue information – References – Dashboard for every site – Images of graves, burials, finds, and osteological material – Interactive diagrams – Download options and more

Towards Open and Reusable Data

- Open Access - Published data are accessible through any common web browser
- Interoperability and reusability: Structured data facilitate the exchange and reuse of information
- Interdisciplinary cooperation is facilitated
- Open-source technologies support sustainable research infrastructure
- Standardised data structures support long-term accessibility

On THANADOS, burial documentation can be presented as an interconnected digital resource, making (osteo-)archaeological evidence more accessible, interoperable, and reusable for future research.

https://thanados.net